

PATH FINDERS
A core committee meeting of the CJP at Abhijeet Dipke's residence in Sambhajinagar, Aug. 5

THE ROAD AHEAD FOR CJP

THE COCKROACH JANTA PARTY IS FOCUSED ON BEING A 'PRESSURE GROUP' FOR NOW, LOOKING TO THE NATION FOR ITS NEXT BIG CAUSE WHILE ALSO PUTTING IN PLACE A STRUCTURE FOR ITSELF

By **Avishek G. Dastidar** *in Delhi and*
Dhaval S. Kulkarni *in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar*

Kya bolti public?" Two days of deliberations later, members of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) have decided to take that question to the streets, fanning out across the nation and listening to what people at the grassroots want. But perhaps the more important message to emerge from the 'Cockroach Conclave' in Sambhajinagar at party convenor Abhijeet Dipke's residence is one of ambition. Come September, those leading the next campaign will no longer be a ragtag collective of Instagrammers rallying in protest. They will represent an organisation whose structure resembles, in all but name, a cadre-based political party.

The party has formalised its structure. Dipke is its founder and national convenor, while Saurav Das of Delhi and Ashutosh Ranka of Jaipur—two of the other most recognisable faces from the Delhi protests—will be co-convenors. Beyond that will be a hierarchical organisation with clearly defined verticals such as Legal Affairs, Policy, Tech, Finance, etc., each with their own backroom squads. Ajinkya Shinde, formerly with the Aam Aadmi Party's youth wing in Maharashtra and a long-time associate of Dipke, will be something like the COO of a political start-up, managing the entire structure.

Apart from the top four, there is Deepak Baliyan, a farm issues activist in Rajasthan, brought into the outfit by Ranka. Heading the legal affairs team is Delhi-based lawyer and former journalist, Ratna Singh. Her team will provide legal aid to anyone who has a run-in with the law while carrying on the movement's work (see *Who's Who in the CJP*).

Purely at the architecture level, the shape the CJP has agreed on for itself resembles the skeleton of a party, with zonal in-charges, state and Lok Sabha constituency units and a dedicated chain of command—not quite how loose movements usually behave. Whether they contest elections now or later is a choice entirely their own. You don't build zonal commands and a disciplined cadre if protest is your only endgame.